OVER 400 SLUMS HAVE COME UP ALL OVER BENGALURU, HOUSING ALMOST A THIRD OF ITS POPULATION. TOTAL HOUSING SHORTAGE IS ESTIMATED TO TOUCH 2.56 MILLION BY 2031

price—as we all experienced in the recent floods."

In a perceptive article, Rohini Nilekani, philanthropist and wife of Nandan Nilekani of Infosys and Aadhaar fame, wrote, 'The recent Bengaluru floods washed up the dirty linen of mismanagement and corruption on the shores of a crumbling city infrastructure. As the elite of East Bengaluru painfully experienced, we cannot be consumers of good governance, we have to create it. If we point one finger at the government, are three fingers pointed back at ourselves? Have we built our sprawling campuses on flood plains? Like it or not, floods, pandemics and air pollution put everyone in the same boat, even if some of us are in the upper deck private cabins. We will have to row together to steer away from the rising waters. Life jackets are under the seat. But the oars are right on top.'

4. Criminal Neglect of Maintenance

The lack of repair and maintenance, especially of stormwater drains and solid waste management, are the fourth folly the city's administrators are guilty of committing over the years. Funds to upgrade and remodel half of Bengaluru's 850-odd km SWD network have been allocated over the past two decades, but progress has been inexplicably slow. In his budget this year, CM Bommai allocated Rs 1,500 crore to upgrade the remaining 400-odd km; following the heavy rains and inundation, he released a further Rs 300 crore for SWDs. With angry citizens demanding answers, Bommai told the assembly last month that tenders for these have been awarded. "But to start work, we must first clear buildings and encroachments that are in the way. That's the situation in Bengaluru today," he said, adding that it will take at least one and a half years to upgrade the SWDs. "But wherever there is an urgent need, we have started work." Among these efforts has been the restoration of the arterial K-100 drain (see Narasimhan *Citizenspeak*).

Bommai, who heads the UDD that oversees the func-



SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

CITIZENSPEAK

'There is no short-cut out of the mess'

ANJALI KAROL MOHAN, *53*
Partner, Integrated Design

Anjali Karol Mohan has been working on master plans for Bengaluru ever since she shifted to the city in 1994. An urban and regional planner, she points to several infirmities. For one, the city is operating on an outdated master plan that was relevant only till 2015. The new plan was withdrawn four years earlier by the state government, seeking modifications, and is yet to be finalised. Mohan says that even if the plan is approved, the statutory framework is archaic and requires a complete overhaul to be in with the times. Among other problems, there is what she calls "an elite capture of public policy". A capitalist consumerist culture has compromised the city's ecology and has impacted the vulnerable. Mohan believes there are no short-cuts. Setting up a task force is not enough. What's needed is bridging the gap between the mechanics of the actual, lived city and the framework the government deploys to manage its growth. It calls "for a democratic bottom-up approach of planning a city", not just the current top-down one, she says.